

Graeme Wright - Unit 550 - Stakeholder Relationships.docx

 Weston College

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Qualification Title	CMI Level 5 Diploma in Operational Management
Unit Number and Title	Unit 550 - Stakeholder Relationships
Centre Name	Weston College
Learner Name	Graeme Wright
Learner CMI Number	P05260463

I  **Graeme Wright** confirm that the work submitted is my own and that I am the sole author of this completed assessment and Sections 1 & 2 of this form have been checked and completed before submission. I have referenced/acknowledged any sources of information and Artificial Intelligence (AI) tools used in the submission; in line with the Qualification Handbook, [CMI's Assessment Guidance Policy](#) and [CMI's Plagiarism, Collusion and Artificial Intelligence \(AI\) Statement](#).

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Section 2 -

Requirement prior to submission	Learner Signature / Initial to confirm
The Assessment Criteria (AC) have been used as headings or I have indicated or sign-posted within my work where each AC has been met.	
Word count is shown on the front sheet and is within the CMI guidelines for the unit.	
All answers relating to the Assessment Criteria (AC) are contained within the body of the text.	
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ASSESSMENT TASKS AND WORD COUNT

Assessment brief **CMI HTQ 550** features the following assessment tasks. Further detail is provided against each assessment task within the brief.

Assessment Task	Learning outcomes covered by assessment method	Assessment criteria	L5 ODM KSB	Guideline word count
1 Write a report titled 'How to manage the complexities of stakeholder relationships'	LO1: Understand the different types and value of stakeholder relationships	1.1 Analyse the types of stakeholder relationships within organisations 1.2 Examine the contractual frameworks for stakeholder engagement and management 1.3 Analyse the role of the manager in managing stakeholder relationships	K13 K14 K15 K16 B2	Approx. 1500 words
2 Write a briefing paper titled 'How to work collaboratively with different stakeholders'	LO2: Understand the methods and challenges of working collaboratively with stakeholders	2.1 Evaluate the use of collaborative working techniques to manage stakeholder relationships 2.2 Outline methods for managing conflict in stakeholder engagement	K14 K15 B2 B3	Approx. 1000 words
3 Write a report titled: 'Approaches used to effectively manage stakeholder relationships'	LO3: Be able to manage stakeholder relationships effectively LO4: Know methods for measuring the impact of stakeholder engagement on organisational performance	3.1 Examine the benefits and challenges for organisations working with different stakeholder groups 3.2 Recommend a process for planning stakeholder engagement 4.1 Examine methods for measuring the impact of stakeholder engagement on organisational performance	S13 S14 S15 B4 B5	Approx. 1500 words

Guideline word count

The written word, whether generated and/or recorded, is expected to form the majority of assessable work produced by Learners at Level 5. The amount and volume of written work for this unit should be broadly comparable to a word count of **4000** words within a margin of +/-10%. The unit also includes additional work in the form of work based evidence. Excessive use of word count is not grounds for referral, however, the CMI reserves the right to return work to the Centre for editing and resubmission by the Learner.

The following are excluded from the written word count: Index or contents pages, headings and subheadings, diagrams, charts and graphs, bibliography.

Please see the **CMI Assessment Guidance Policy** for further guidance, along with the guidance on **Command Verb Definitions**.

LEARNER EVIDENCE

'How to manage the complexities of stakeholder relationships'

16 a Digital Coach I need to learn to understand people. There are a lot of different kinds of people in an organisation, with different interests, different needs, and different personalities. You cannot just dive in without a plan. It's like this when we consider building stakeholder relationships. It's about understanding people, building trust, and adapting your approach to meet the specialist circumstances. We need to think strategically and carefully, because, as R. Edward

5 eman (Freeman, 1984) argued, a stakeholder is "any group or individual who can affect, or be affected by, the achievement of the organisation's objectives". In other words, all sorts of people affect the success of an organisation's objectives, at all levels, and so each stakeholder group will need a different approach to build strong, trustworthy, and reliable relationships, otherwise, as Freeman warned, there could be "consequences of ignoring stakeholders for corporate survival".

10 Analyse the types of stakeholder relationships within organisations

Building strong relationships with stakeholders across Weston College is vital to my role as a Digital Coach. They are not only important for me to ensure that I can deliver on my KPI's, but also, as Freeman noted, inherently reciprocal. Academics, Colin Eden and Fran Ackermann developed a model in the 1990's called the *Power vs Interest Grid* which I try to consider when thinking about those people I work with regularly.

High Power / High Interest

These are the "key players" in the quadrant. People like my manager – Head of Digital Education – and the Heads of Areas. Although my manager directly influences my role, the success of strategic initiatives also depends on the engagement of Heads of Areas and their teams. These people have the power to influence curriculum design, staff development, and the level of engagement and interest they have in our digital transformation agenda. The challenge for my role is to align our priorities with their strategic needs, and an essential approach for delivering high-quality education. Graham Kelly discussed that it is these stakeholders with a "disproportionate impact" who can "make or break an organisation's plans".

High Interest / Low Power

This is my primary audience – the academic staff and their learners. Despite having less power than the Heads of Areas, they have a huge interest in the success of digital learning. However, as a group they can influence through collective action, demanding attention to their current and future needs. In my role as a Digital Coach, it is this group that I am constantly engaging with, influencing, and exposing them to new digital learning approaches to enhance their practice.

Low Interest / High Power

There are external groups, like the exam boards and regulators like Ofsted, who hold significant power to influence our direction. Their inspection frameworks and policies, and the evolving digital skills agenda, combine to shape the direction of digital education. They might not be entirely interested in my day-to-day role, or the work I'm doing with the Digital Champions and the 21st Century Learning Design programme, but they hold the power to influence our direction.

Low Interest / Low Power

This group may contain contractors or partners, such as Jisc, LinkedIn Learning, Microsoft, Adobe, Google, ThingLink, Canva, and others. They have little interest in our direction, and limited power. Engagement with this group is typically minimal and one-way, focusing on leveraging their tools and services to support our digital transformation journey.

1.2 Examine the contractual frameworks for stakeholder engagement and management.

Despite my approach to work being personal and reflective, the way I build stakeholder relationships is often underpinned by a more formal approach. I have collaborated with my manager to hold meetings with Heads of Areas, understanding their priorities, their team needs, and strategising an approach to support them in their own digital learning reporting responsibilities. The outcome of these meetings is the sharing of a relaxed but formal contract. These agreements establish clear expectations for how I will engage with them, and support their teams, providing clarity on my and their expectations. As a Digital Coach the impact and success of my role relies on these more formal structures, even if I'm not directly involved in creating them.

Beyond my work with the Heads of Areas, the college has formal agreements with both internal and external stakeholders. These lay out the terms of the relationship in Service-Level Agreements (SLAs). They support the relationships with organisations such as Jisc, Microsoft, and other digital partners. For example, we enter into legally binding contracts with providers such as Century, who we pay a license fee over a certain period. In return, we have access to developing learning tools, content, and support. The agreements we have with these organisations clearly define the level of service and support we can expect from them. A good SLA prevents misunderstandings by clearly defining expectations, ensuring all parties commit to nurturing a successful relationship.

In addition to external agreements, Weston College maintains other legal agreements with internal stakeholders, like academic staff, professional learner services, and facilities. These terms are set out in employee contracts. These contracts cover the expectations both the college and the member of staff has regarding terms and conditions, working hours and days, the scope of the work, the level of pay, and the support the college will provide their employee. My role as a Digital Coach in supporting staff with their digital upskilling and development is a demonstration of how the college commits to the professional development of their staff, which in turn develops loyalty and improves staff retention.

However, not all challenges can be predicted or avoided through the negotiation of contracts. Sometimes the very goals and intentions of stakeholders can be the obstacles and organisation needs to navigate. This is where we find a conflict of interest. Management theorist Richard Pettinger (Pettinger, 2010) highlights the impact financial investors can have on the direction of travel. Large financial investors are often prioritised, "whether or not this is the correct course of action for the particular organisation". The power imbalance that is created here makes the maintenance of relationships difficult. In the example of Weston College, an external donation from a tech company may fund a new campus, or facilities. They may have different interests, such as how they can influence the public relations, expect prominent branding, set a clear return on investment with challenging milestones. The senior leadership team may feel pressured to prioritise these interests at the expense of other stakeholders, leading to a potential conflict of interest, especially if the investors have different values to that of the college and the staff. As a Digital Coach, I may not be directly involved in these influencing decisions, however, I must remain aware of how power dynamics such as these can influence the priorities and morale of staff I support. My specific role extends beyond wider formal agreements and instead exists in the spaces around the human needs – building trust and developing communication channels to bridge any gaps that develop. Warren Bennis (Bennis, N.D.) said, "all claims deserve consideration, but some claims are more important than others". It is my job to listen carefully to these claims and navigate them with care and empathy, ensuring we continue to move forward in line with our digital transformation objectives.

1 Analyse the role of the manager in managing stakeholder relationships

18 The strategic direction for managing stakeholder relationships is set by my manager. This top-down planning process is essential for guiding the engagement strategies I employ with academic staff and wider college stakeholders. My engagement strategies are not just about information sharing, or delivering training and support, it is significantly more strategic and multi-layered, requiring careful planning and consideration against organisational objectives and departmental KPIs. Thomas Krick and Maya Forstater developed a five-stage framework for engagement which my role aligns perfectly with.

Collaborating closely with the Head of Digital Education and Heads of Areas, my work starts at the Think Strategically phase. We explore the needs of each Area, their curriculum delivery strategy, current staff development needs, and any future digital learning projects and convert digital transformation objectives into actionable and impactful targets, with specific milestones. For example, my work with academic staff in understanding the way we can support learners in the use of AI will both improve the concerns around malpractice and address the scope of Ofsted's investigations into how AI is used to support learners' experiences, outcomes, and safety.

Within the Analysis and Plan stage I have collected, in collaboration with the Head of Digital Education, data that will inform our personalised action plans. This includes a review of digital learning environments, digital learning hours and how these will be delivered and measured, and current staffing confidence and competence with digital tools. The

13 Personalised action plans presented will in effect act as an agreement to ensure my support is always tailored to the specific needs and expectations of the key stakeholders involved.

The Strengthen Engagement Capabilities framework notes that successful plans may need to "strengthen its capacities to engage stakeholders". By developing training material, resources, toolkits, and running mentoring sessions to build digital literacy and confidence, I will be directly working to strengthen the engagement capabilities across the college. A good example of this is through the Digital Champions 21st Century Learning Design programme, where we will be leveraging the expertise of these volunteer internal stakeholders to implement the 21CLD framework and develop case studies.

Following on from the investigation and planning phases comes the Design the Process and Engage stage. Here is where the planning is put into action using a blend of engagement and communication strategies. The DigiZone SharePoint site acts as a form of one-way communication, sharing newsletters and event information to drive consistent and transparent engagement across the college. In contrast to this, my mentoring and coaching sessions are an example of two-way communication, developing an open dialogue and feedback mechanism with staff. Using strategies such as these, I can facilitate a higher level of engagement that is crucial for developing staff buy-in.

Finally, we come to the Act, Review and Report stage. This is a continuous cycle of learning and adapting. My work with the Heads of Areas will establish 2 key touch points to guide the support I offer towards meeting their targets set out in the personalised action plan. By setting regular milestones we can ensure that adjustments are made in a timely and appropriate manner. By exploring the data, feedback, and reviews of digital learning environments, I can refine our engagement approaches and ensure our relationship remains strong and agile, an inherently reciprocal relationship towards our own digital strategy objectives.

1 Defining Paper: How to Work Collaboratively with Different Stakeholders

Subject: Collaborative Techniques for Stakeholder Engagement and Managing Conflict

Summary: Within this paper I will evaluate the collaborative techniques of the Six Thinking Hats and the MoSCoW model. I will reflect on how these methods build a collective energy and help drive innovation through our digital transformation. I will also explore an approach for managing conflict through the principles of negotiation and Alternative Dispute Resolution (ADR).

Background: As a Digital Coach, I work on a range of projects, from discovering, testing, and integrating innovative technologies to leading professional development initiatives. Central to the success of these projects is effective stakeholder engagement. Communication must be clear, along with robust methods for encouraging strong collaborative problem-solving and conflict resolution. Listening to all voices and inputs is especially important.

Purpose of the paper: I aim to evaluate my use of collaborative techniques and approach to conflict resolution. As a reflective practitioner I will explore how these methods are applied in practice to develop reciprocal relationships, foster strong collaboration and engagement, and align to our digital transformation strategic goals across the college.

1 Evaluate the use of collaborative working techniques to manage stakeholder relationships

Following my previous experience as a teacher and subject leader, and in my current role as Digital Coach, I've found that, as Friedman and Miles state (Friedman & Miles, 2006), collaboration is a "higher level of engagement" that unlocks incredible knowledge and creativity from within a community. Working with academic staff, Heads of Area, and the Digital Champions, I find myself in a privileged position to put these principles into practice. It is this type of work and position that enables me to align with the Strength Engagement Capabilities and Design the Process and Engage stages presented through the Krick and Forstater framework (Krick, Forstater, et al., 2005).

- **Strategic Meetings with Heads of Areas:** By holding regular meetings with Heads of Areas I can ensure we collaborate and co-create personalised action plans, develop, and promote CPD opportunities to meet their specific needs. This approach is highly effective because of the direct relationship it has with high-power, high-interest stakeholders throughout the process. Working together like this allows us to define objectives, built on strong trust and alignment to mutual goals, which are likely to be more successfully implemented into their team. Although this approach is challenging on balancing my time demands and other responsibilities, the long-term benefits of these projects and future stakeholder buy-in make it worthwhile.
- **The Six Thinking Hats Model:** When working through the 21CLD programme with the Digital Champions, I will use **Edward De Bono's Six Thinking Hats model (De Bono, 1999)** to encourage collaborative thinking. This provides a structured approach to problem solving by exploring real-world issues from the six different views points. These hats have distinct colours to represent the different thinking states. The white hat for objectivity, the green hat for creativity, and the black hat for risk analysis, for example. This exercise ensures that everyone's viewpoint is considered and allows us to explore solutions through a sense of empathy and cooperation and not reduces the risk of conflict.
- **The MoSCoW Model and Digital Tools:** I will use this model during mentoring sessions and co-creating CPD approaches with Heads of Areas. It will allow me to clarify what they and their teams need from using digital tools. Essentially, this framework helps me to "cut to the chase" (CMI, 2020) by organising needs into Must, Should, Could, and Won't. The MoSCoW model clearly defines the scope of the project and manages expectations, focusing efforts on the most critical priorities. By utilising the DigiZone SharePoint site for sharing these resources, I will develop a vital tool that will foster a collaborative environment beyond face-to-face training and support.

These approaches show how what I do works and provides a strong foundation for collaborative techniques.

9 Outline methods for managing conflict in stakeholder engagement

Unfortunately, conflict is an inevitable part of any reciprocal relationship. My goal, however, is to handle it constructively and empathetically before it escalates. I find the most suitable approach is to be proactive in leading conflict resolution through iterative negotiation rather than waiting for it to become too late and cause serious damage. Through this approach, managers can develop trust and inspire innovation (Fisher & Ury, 1981).

It's important to start with identifying potential conflict which often begin where power imbalances or competing priorities lay. For example, a Head of Area may not identify, as a priority, CPD time for staff in understanding how AI can be used in supporting day-to-day tasks, however they may be concerned with staff workloads and potential burnout.

8 The approach I would adopt here is based on Roger Fisher and William Ury's paper "Getting to Yes: Negotiating Agreement Without Giving In" (Fisher & Ury, 1981), and utilising the four principles of successful negotiation.

- **Separate people from problems:** By trying to keep the discussions factual and focused on the task at hand we reduce the impact emotions can have on a problem. We can see ourselves as working "side by side, attacking the problem, not each other" (Fisher & Ury, 1991) in this way.
- **Focus on interests rather than positions:** Focusing more intentionally on the problems allows me to find solutions that satisfy the true need instead of focusing on the desires people may have, which may not be the problem in the first place. For example, changing digital tools from one to another, when instead the CPD need is on *how* to implement the tool effectively and not replace it entirely. Without the full understanding of *how* to implement digital tools, the success of the 'solution' is limited.
- **Invent options for mutual gain:** After discussing objectives and interests with stakeholders, for example, the Heads of Areas and their various conflicting priorities, we can encourage the creation of multiple options. This allows us to keep our options open and discover a solution that works for everyone.
- **Insist on using objective criteria:** Analysing the problem and solution through data enables us to focus on "facts" and less on the emotively driven anecdotal evidence. Although there is a place for this, the facts and data present a clear and transparent needs analysis and impact assessment.

Sometimes informal negotiations fail and so the concept of Alternative Dispute Resolution (ADR) provides a structured way to resolve disputes outside of a formal court system. This is an important strategic consideration, as court proceedings are expensive and time consuming. Engaging an impartial third party can help resolve the issue through mediation or arbitration for the more serious cases. Understanding the influence and impact potential power dynamics, as highlighted by Richard Pettinger's theory that large financial partners are prioritised (Pettinger, 2010), is crucial. It allows me to remain objective and sensitive to influences and their impact on staff morale and priorities, and ensures communication remains transparent.

Recommended Action

To enable me to develop a collaborative and productive approach to stakeholder relationships at Weston College, I will:

- 15 • Use frameworks such as the Six Thinking Hats and the MoSCoW model to structure collaborative projects and manage expectations.
- Apply the principles of negotiation to navigate conflicts early and informally, supporting a culture of collaboration, communication, and trust.
- Maintain records of project work, and how I manage stakeholder relationships, as a record of best practice that can be shared with others.

1 Report: Approaches Used to Effectively Manage Stakeholder Relationships

14 the Digital Coach at Weston College I'm responsible for implementing digital transformation and organisational objectives into strategic practice. This is a direct reminder of how my role exists as part of a wider stakeholder relations strategy from the executive team level. It requires a deep understanding of how to maximise the value of relationships, but also navigate the inevitable challenges that come along. The following report will explore the strategic approaches, frameworks, models and metrics I can utilise to manage this.

6 Examine the benefits and challenges for organisations working with different stakeholder groups

Done well, there are significant benefits for the College and its staff in managing effective stakeholder relationships. But it does require constant care and vigilance of unforeseen or carefully managed challenges.

Benefits of Engagement

The primary benefit that the overall success and survival of the College. There are several advantages to proactively engaging with stakeholders.

- **Access to Expertise and Innovation:** There is a wide range of expertise within the College, and it is part of my role to find ways to leverage this. My approach this year is to tap into staff knowledge and expertise through the 21st Century Learning Design programme, to co-create case studies and share best practice. This is underpinned by Joseph Heagney (2016) who identifies expertise as an important form of non-financial assistance that can "fill gaps in the organisation's knowledge base".
- **Enhanced Loyalty and Commitment:** By actively engaging staff in digital CPD initiatives, and in helping them develop digital skills that can directly improve their work and outcomes, we can build trust and loyalty amongst staff. Benefits like increased productivity, innovation, and staff retention will support the College's wider success.
- **Improved Reputation and Buy-in:** The reputation of Weston College is vitally important, particularly amongst our external stakeholders like employers and regulators. This directly influences funding and student recruitment. By engaging with our external stakeholders, we can build greater buy-in and long term financial and academic success.

Challenges of Engagement

1 is often difficult to balance the varying demands of different stakeholders and stakeholder groups.

- **Conflict of Interest and Power Imbalance:** The biggest challenge is in knowing who to prioritise and when, especially when interests do not align. This can lead to a conflict of interest. Richard Pettinger (2010) states that those who have a large financial investment in an organisation often have their interests prioritised, "whether or not this is the correct course of action for the particular organisation". By understanding these potential shifts in priorities and potential power dynamics I can ensure that my support for internal staff is adapted to reflect, and mitigate for, influences on staff morale.
- **Diverging Values and Culture:** Clear transparency of values and culture are vital in ensuring a sustainable relationship with external partners. For example, if the College's pedagogical values are not in alignment with a digital partner's, we can experience serious friction and potentially damaging relationships. The impact this may have is in the mistrust of using the service, or not seeking to maximise the usefulness of the service despite the financial cost in the contract.

1. Recommend a process for planning stakeholder engagement

17. Using the **Krick and Forstater five-stage** framework for planning **stakeholder engagement** I will ensure I am being strategic rather than reactive. Aligned with organisational objectives, this framework provides me with a clear and structured approach.

1. **Think Strategically (Stage 1):** Start with the College's overarching strategic objectives and ensure departmental digital transformation objectives are mapped. This will ensure that the Head of Digital Education, my manager, can direct our team, and my engagement strategies to fit with the overarching goals.
2. **Analyse and Plan (Stage 2):** Next, we need to research stakeholders needs. By completing primary research into our external partners and internal stakeholders needs – CPD analysis, reviews of digital learning environments, work to be carried out through our work with Head of Areas – and by aligning this with government and Ofsted reports through a secondary research phase, we can ensure that we have created a clear and personalised engagement action plan.
3. **Strengthen Engagement Capabilities (Stage 3):** My role directly addresses the need to develop appropriate systems and processes for effective organisational engagement. By providing training material, toolkits, and developing the DigiZone SharePoint site, I can ensure internal stakeholders have everything they need to build engagement capabilities and embed changes.
4. **Design the Process and Engage (Stage 4):** This critical phase turns the planning into action to ensure we achieve crucial and specific objectives. I use mentoring sessions, Heads of Area meetings, and wider staff team training events as a form of two-way communication for high-power groups. For broader audiences I can influence change through one-way communication methods like newsletters and the DigiZone SharePoint site.
5. **Act, Review & Report (Stage 5):** Organisational change does not have a specific end point but instead is driven by a continuous cycle of learning and adapting within engagement strategies. Elements that involve acting on feedback, reviewing the processes, and communicating outcomes ensures transparency, accountability, and continuous improvement along the digital transformation strategy.

1. Examine methods for measuring the impact of stakeholder engagement on organisational performance

Understanding **the impact of engagement** and intervention is essential for future success and justifying future investment. I will examine the impact of my engagement strategies and the methods for measuring this.

Measuring Impact Methods

- **Tangible Impact:** This is what affects the College's finances and operational abilities. For example, a lower employee turnover will keep learning experiences more stable and will likely increase student outcomes and retention rates.
- **Intangible Impact:** This is harder to quantify. However, by using a post-service survey that contributes towards generating a Net Promoter Score (NPS) reflecting the support staff feel they get in developing their digital skills and transformation, we can refine our approach through analysing feedback, and use this to support strategic decisions, working towards building a positive overall NPS. This supports the approach for proactive stakeholder relationships because we can ensure support is relevant and timely. Where staff feel supported and valued there is likely to be a culture of engagement and loyalty. Conversely, where the CPD experience is poor there tends to be a higher turnover of teaching staff, fluctuations in terms of the quality of learning experiences, and therefore academic success that can vary significantly. This in turn affects the reputation of Weston College and then student admissions, which finally affects the College's finances and operational capabilities.

11 The Balanced Scorecard

Robert Kaplan and David Norton presented the “Balanced Scorecard” which presents a more holistic view of performance. There are four interdependent perspectives:

1. **Financial:** This looks at how costs may be managed more effectively because of improved staff efficiencies and reduced recruitment costs.
2. **Customer:** Here we explore the satisfaction levels gathered from students about their College, wider services, and their courses.
3. **Internal Processes:** Systems that allow for more efficient and productive working habits can directly impact organisational costs.
4. **Learning and Innovation:** Now we investigate the impact CPD and workplace culture has on the capabilities and skill sets of staff to become more ambitious, increase efficacy and more engaged.

By tracking these four perspectives and their related Key Performance Indicators (KPIs) we can gather objective quantitative data and subjective qualitative data. These two forms of data analytics can help the College ensure its strategic efforts produce sustainable success.

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